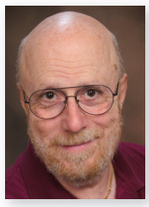
PHOTOGRAPHS BY KURT HERTZOG

Alterations after turning

Kurt Hertzog explores some different methods of adding decoration after turning

KURT HERTZOG



Kurt is a professional woodturner, demonstrator and teacher and writes for various woodturning and woodworking publications in the United States as well as contributing to *Woodturning* magazine. He is on the Pen Makers' Guild Council and is currently president of the American Association of Woodturners (AAW).

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Taking your nearly completed piece and intentionally altering it may seem like heresy. Carving, piercing, painting, pyrography, distressing or other after-turning alterations may seem like degradation after you've taken the time and trouble to make it flawless. With beautiful wood, you can create a simple turning allowing the beauty of the wood to speak for itself. However plain, boring woods can usually benefit from a little help. Past articles have touched on painting, piercing, inlaying and other after-turning ideas. This month we'll explore carving, pyrographing and minor distressing. These are just a few additional things you can do to add a bit of interest. While there are artists who have taken these techniques to a pinnacle rarely reached by the rest of us, my goal is to plant the seeds of simple things with which you can begin to experiment. Like most woodturning, there are tools that can be bought to ease the tasks but we'll focus on the simple tools yet show some of the available tools.

Safety

In addition to the usual cautions about eye protection and PPE as needed whenever you are in the shop, please take special care with the tools suggested for these modifications. Carving tools need to be incredibly sharp to be effective, so using a carving glove as appropriate is a wise idea regardless of your workholding method. A slip with a carving tool is always a possibility so protect yourself from any mishap. For our pyrography, especially with a torch, use caution where you perform this. Be certain you do this in an appropriate place and keep an extinguisher handy. Protect yourself as needed against the potential for burns. Working in a safe environment that is clean and fire safe and taking care with these hot items is paramount. The burning materials should always be done with plenty of ventilation to avoid breathing the vapours.

Carver's gloves from Kevlar protect your hands from sharp carving tools. A welder's glove may be helpful when using a torch

Key points

- Use woodburners and torches in a well-ventilated, fire safe, clear area.
- Avoid breathing the vapours of burning.
- Protect your hands with PPE when using sharp tools or heat.

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